shahaadat hai unki (brother, what a life he had, what a huge sacrifice he made)," he said. He said he has tried to get the rights, but it never materialised. I was smiling as I looked at him. He had said what I had in mind. Diljit refused to quote a fee for the role. He felt it would be a shame if he asked for money to play such a monumental figure. Regardless, my producer paid him.

Q. Why change the name from *Punjab '95* to *Satluj*?

The working title was *Gallughara*. *Punjab '95* was the title with which we submitted the film to Toronto International Film Festival, where the film was supposed to have its world premiere in 2023. When the film was about to release on ZEE5, I got a call from a producer, saying they want to change the title. I said we can go with *Satluj* as that title is also registered with us. I always felt the river has a deep resonance with the entire film. That is where

"People can decide who is on the wrong side of history. If they feel *Satluj* is one-sided, they are free to make their film. There is freedom of speech"

the bodies were thrown, including Khalra's. It would be poetic justice. We offered the fresh title to ZEE5 and they decided to go with it.

Q. The film's getting adulation but also plenty of criticism. Detractors say it depicts only one side of the story about the Punjab insurgency. Your comment.

I am a filmmaker, not a criminal or a politician. I made a film about a character I believe in. For three years, when we didn't get the censor certificate, we were told it would create a law-and-order situation in Punjab. Now that the film has come out, what it has done is to bring the entire state—regardless of religion, caste and status—together. The ones who are inciting violence are the ones who have a problem with people uniting, saying, "*Punjab ke Hinduon, tum kab jaagoge* (Hindus of Punjab, when will you wake up)?" The statement is in public. People can decide who is on the wrong side of history. If they feel *Satluj* is a one-sided story, they are absolutely free to make a film from the other side. It is a free country and there's free speech.

Q. Do you know why ZEE5 withdrew the film? Was there pressure from the government?

ZEE5 was asked to remove the film. They received a letter from the Information & Broadcasting ministry. Then, the government formed a committee. Two days later, they wrote to the platform, saying the ban continues.

Q. You have talked about how the CBFC asked for 127 cuts. How did you realise they wanted to stall the film's release?

We wanted to submit the film to international film festivals, so we decided to get an early censor certificate and sent it to the CBFC in early 2023. They came back, asking for 21 cuts, which didn't make any sense to us, hence we decided to approach the Bombay High Court. While proceedings were going on, we got to know the film was selected for Toronto. Later, my producer Ronnie got a call, asking him to withdraw the matter from the high court as well as from TIFF, and to do an out-of-court settlement.

Unfortunately, the out-of-court settlement went on for two and a half years and led from 21 cuts to 127 cuts. It made us eventually realise that this is a futile exercise and that they are just buying time and stalling the release. ■

more boys were available for the "struggle".

The lower judiciary in the state was in disarray, with most judges too frightened to take up cases involving terrorists apprehended by the police. The situation only worsened after judicial officers came under direct attack, including judge Hans Raj Kaushik, who was shot dead inside his own courtroom in Moga (see case study, *Murder in a Courtroom*). Meanwhile, in the villages, terrorist chiefs like Manochahal in Tarn Taran and Gurjant Singh Budhsinghwala settled everything—from disputes over land and the apportioning of farm water to matrimonial differences.

THE POST-BLUESTAR DECADE SAW A RISE IN THE WRIT OF KHALISTANI TERRORIST OUTFITS AND THE COLLAPSE OF CIVIL ADMINISTRATION, LOWER JUDICIARY AND THE MEDIA

The media, too, became an obvious target. The station director of All India Radio at Chandigarh, R.K. Talib, was shot dead on December 6, 1990. M.L. Manchanda, AIR's station director at Patiala, was abducted by Babbar Khalsa terrorists who demanded that all local broadcasting be in Punjabi, not Hindi; he was beheaded on May 27, 1992, after the government failed to meet the kidnappers' deadline. AIR promptly discontinued all Hindi-language broadcasts in Punjab and Chandigarh; Doordarshan followed suit, further ensuring its announcers adhered to the salwar-kameez and dupatta dress code on air. Even Punjab's public relations department capitulated and began issuing press notes in Gurmukhi.

Exorcising Past Ghosts

While *Satluj* portrays DGP Gill as the butcher who ordered extra-judicial killings of militants and indicates that Khalra may have been killed at his behest, many experts regard Gill's second tenure between 1991 and 1995 as the reason extremism was crushed. In close collaboration with the army, Gill successfully oversaw the 1992 state assembly